

**DECONSTRUCTING HARRY: MEN, MASCULINITY AND ORGANIZATION - A
CRITICAL REVIEW**

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ABSTRACT

This paper reviews the use of ‘masculinity’ to address organizational discrimination. Agreeing with those who argue for a focus on masculinities at work, the paper cautions against a binary opposition between the ‘bad’ masculine and the ‘good’ feminine, and the separation of masculinity from the lived experiences of people.

Masculinity, Management Theory

INTRODUCTION

This paper began as a form of Acker & van Houten Part II. Acker and van Houten (1974), as we know, revisited the classic Hawthorne Studies from a feminist perspective -- exposing the weaknesses of neglecting gender in studies of organization. Acker & van Houten’s (1974) feminist analysis, suggesting that “sex power differentials” played a crucial role in the original studies of organizational behavior in the Hawthorne works, became influential in encouraging a new generation of feminist organizational research (Mills & Tancred, 1992). The recent interest in masculinity and organizational behavior (Cheng, 1996; Collinson, 1988, 1992; Collinson & Hearn, 1994, 1996; Jacques, 1997; Maier, 1991, 1993, 1997; Messerschmidt, 1995; Mills, in press) led us believe that perhaps there was a similar research job to be done in documenting the development of masculinist organization thought by a revisiting of classic studies. Certainly most of the early management and organizational theorist (e.g. Frederick Taylor, Frank Gilbreth, Fritz Roethlisberger) were men, and Taylor’s pioneering work was premised exclusively on male steelworkers; the contribution of the few women theorists in the field (e.g. Lillian Gilbreth, Mary Parker Follett) were either ignored or played down until recently (Sheriff & Campbell, 1992)

As we began to lay out how we would proceed to study the development of masculinist thought in organizational analysis a number of questions dogged our progress and, ultimately, encouraged us, instead, to undertake a critical review of the notion of masculinity itself. Among the questions confronting us were: What is masculinity? Is masculinity primarily a biological or a social construct? To what extent is the term masculinity dependent on a binary opposite of femininity? Are there different forms of masculinity and what is the significance of the various forms? Is there a dominant or hegemonic form of masculinity? To what extent can there be masculine (and feminine) characteristics that are separable from men (and women)? And how do the answers to these questions affect how we make sense of behavior in organizations, particularly with regard to addressing gender discrimination?

What is masculinity? At a common-sense level masculinity is about men and being manly. But social science is about questioning rather than reproducing common-sense understandings, and beneath the surface of common-sense we find that masculinity is problematic on a number of grounds, including its relationship to biological determinants, particular or dominant social characteristics, men and women, and the problematic ways in which it is currently being used in management literature.

MASCULINITY AND THE NATURE/NURTURE DEBATE

The most fundamental debate remains the issue of whether people *are* male and female due to essential in-born characteristics (nature) or whether they *become* male and female through a process of social construction (nurture). Of course outside of fantasy, fiction, everyday discourse, and organizational behavior texts, people rarely adopt one or the other of these extreme positions.

Although it is ‘common sense’ within much of the social science literature that a person’s sexual identity owes much to a combination of nature and nurture, there is an apparent difference in how far one goes in a particular direction. Popenoe (1980:) provides a classic example of a

‘balanced’ perspective, i.e., one that attempts to take into account the influence of nature and nurture on the ‘gendering of persons:’

“The social importance of biological sex differences is complex and not yet clearly understood. Although we know that males and females are genetically, hormonally, and anatomically different from each other, we do not yet know to what extent these differences influence behavior. . . Although genetic and hormonal influences may predispose humans to certain kinds of behavior, these predispositions probably account for only a small part of the complex masculine and feminine gender identities that we find in societies” (1980: 166-168).

Despite appearances to the contrary, Popenoe’s approach is very much in the direction of a biological, or essentialist, account. His use of the terms ‘males’ and ‘females’ presupposes a reality rooted within biology.

“To what extent do hormones influence behavior? There is evidence that some types of behavior do differ in males and females, probably as a result of hormonal conditioning. Boys seem to expend more energy than girls, especially in outdoor activities and sports, are more territorial in play, and engage more in competitive rivalry for positions of dominance. Girls, on the other hand, are more likely to rehearse the roles of parenthood” (1980: 167).

Oakley’s (1972) foundational distinction between ‘sex’ (the biological division into females and male) and ‘gender’ (the parallel and socially unequal division into femininity and masculinity) attempted to overcome the biology/culture division by playing down the significance of biology and focusing attention on culture in the making of men and women. The distinction between ‘sex’ and ‘gender’ gained wide usage but, as Oakely herself later went on to question, “the two terms presupposes a degree of prior certainty about the separation of innate and environmental differences” (1981: 41).

Moving towards a social constructionist view of “sexual identity” Mackie (1987) revisits the sex/gender division, arguing that the distinction is problematic because both elements involve an interchange of biology and culture.

“At first, the sex/gender distinction seemed straightforward enough. However, it was soon noticed that even sophisticated researchers tend to use the terms interchangeably, not because they are careless, but because it is often difficult, even impossible, to

disentangle biology from culture . . . A second problem with the sex/gender terminology is a tendency to view *both* sex and gender as inevitable, dichotomous qualities, deeply rooted in human nature . . . A third and related difficulty is the propensity to understand gender as a property of individuals, not a principle of social organization” (1987: 3-4).

Mackie, nonetheless, suggests that culture is the dominant element in the sex/gender relationship:

“Although the sex/gender distinction is imperfect, it is the best conceptual device to label biological versus sociological maleness and femaleness. The distinction allows us to ask these questions: What relationships exist between gender and sex, i.e., what is biological and what is sociocultural? How, in modern society, do the *minor* biological differences between the sexes come to assume such vast social importance?” (1987: 5, our emphasis added).

Behavioral Implications of Sex/Gender Distinctions

Those theories that lean in the direction of the biological significance of sex inform ‘sex difference’ research, which focuses on comparisons between men and women (Rakow, 1986). In the following example the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ are used unproblematically, implying fundamental, taken-for-granted differences between two distinct biological categories of people. This is manifest in a confusion between sex and gender, yet at the same time one that exaggerates between- as it ignores within-sex differences. This frequently results in stereotypical characterizations of women and men:

“An extensive review of the literature suggests two conclusions regarding gender and leadership. First, the similarities between men and women tend to outweigh the differences. Second, what differences there are seem to be that women fall back on a more democratic leadership style, while men feel more comfortable with a directive style” (Robbins, 1998: 377).

In all fairness the author is attempting to argue that ‘women’ and ‘men’ (as analytic categories) should be given equal opportunity to occupy management positions and that, if anything, ‘women’ have a unique, more socially acceptable and effective style of leading -- a point that we shall take up later. Nonetheless, it can be argued that, in the process, Robbins (1998) actually strengthens the view that men and women are biologically different and, thus, may have to be

treated differently and perhaps unequally. This latter point can be seen more clearly in the following excerpts from a leading Canadian text book on organizational behavior.

“For most individual characteristics there is no difference between females and males. . . However, there is evidence that:
Females are better at verbal ability, though the gap is narrowing;
Males are better at spatial and mathematical/quantitative ability;
Males are more aggressive;
Females are better at perceptual speed and dexterity;
Females mature faster than males, but this difference declines with age;
On average adult males are taller, heavier, and stronger than females.”
(Field, 1998: 145).

The author follows up with “implications for organizations and their hiring practices”. Drawing on the example of a firefighter, a highly gendered type of job with which to be exemplifying ostensibly generalizable implications, he asserts that:

“Even though some women are able to meet the standards of physical performance set for a firefighter . . . a woman in top condition still finds it difficult to physically outperform a man in top condition. Essentially, in this high performance screening, biological differences between males and females are making the difference in who is hired” (1988: 146).

Field (1998) does not question who established the standards in the first place, who gets to judge whom, nor whether one level of ‘approved’ performance should be valued higher than another level of ‘approved’ performance. Instead, he asks: “What is fair? Should women be hired even though they don’t perform quite as well on the physical tests as the top men? Would that be discriminating against the men who would have been hired had the women not been hired?” (Field, 1998: 146). He concludes by saying that there are no easy answers to these questions, yet he has already suggested that ‘men’ are, at least in some circumstances, more capable than ‘women.’

Among the many criticisms of the biological approach is that it reinforces discriminatory notions of difference by suggesting that males and females consist of *inherent* differences, and that these differences -- rather than cultural practices -- shape opportunity (Clarke & Lawson, 1985; Eichler & Lapointe, 1985; Feldberg & Glenn, 1979). As Margrit Eichler (1980: quoted in

Richardson, 1981: 169) has argued, by asking people what they believe about the differences between the sexes, researchers may be reifying the stereotypes; “the stereotype take on a life of its own, becomes normative, and empirical reality is measured and evaluated against the norm. Reality has been stood on its head.”

Nonetheless, in studies of management and organization a biological approach is evident in much of the liberal feminism that informed the development of a ‘women in management’ (WIM) perspective in recent years (Calás & Smircich, 1992). The WIM perspective played an important role in the development of anti-discrimination and equity perspectives within management studies, and in rallying ‘women’ to challenge discriminatory practices. Suggestions for change include encouraging women to act more like men (Henning & Jardin, 1977), a reliance on the development of a critical mass of women to change management style and practice (Gutek, 1985; Kanter, 1977; Sheppard, 1989), and encouraging the development of processes of androgyny whereby women and men adopt gender-neutral styles of behavior (Bem, 1974; Bem, 1981). These suggestions have all been criticized within feminist organizational literature for focusing on individual change, or placing an over-reliance on supposed ‘female’ qualities, while ignoring the ‘masculinist discourse’ within which organizational action is constructed, occurs and is maintained (Calás & Smircich, 1997; Ferguson, 1984; Mills & Chiamonte, 1991). However, as we shall argue later, biological reference points have proven problematic for social constructionist, post-structuralist and post-feminist arguments.

In an effort to overcome the problem of biology as destiny social constructionist theory has ignored, de-emphasized, or contested biology through a focus on ‘gender processes’, or cultural factors that shape people’s images of what it is to be a ‘man’ or a ‘woman’. This approach has been important in drawing attention to the structure (Agocs, Burr, & Somerset, 1992; Bradshaw-Camball, 1991; Kanter, 1977) and processes (Benson, 1992; Burton, 1987; Rakow, 1986; Mills, 1992) of organizations in the construction of gendered identities. This approach encourages the organizational researcher to identify how forms of structure and process contribute to the relative worth of masculine and feminine characteristics in a given

organizational situation. Kanter (1977), for example, argues that the ‘opportunity structure’ of an organization acts as a powerful signal of the worth of ‘women’ in comparison to ‘men’ and, in the process, acts as a powerful symbol of gender identity; organizational power becomes strongly associated with masculinity to the extent that one defines the other. In a similar vein the work of Virginia Schein (Brenner, Tomkiewicz, & Schein, 1989; Schein, 1973, 1975, 1994) demonstrates how associations of ‘men’ with managing led ‘male’ and ‘female’ managers alike to view leadership as something fundamentally masculine.

Examining the processes of work numerous feminist accounts have revealed the links between forms of work and work structure and masculinity, demonstrating that the way that organization, managing, and work are all conceived is favorable to ‘men’ rather than ‘women’ -- particularly when it comes to the employment and promotion of women. Within this framework masculinity and forms of work often become conflated and inseparable. French (1985), for example, argues that the harshness of industrial work may have, in its early stages, fueled the need in male workers to develop new images of womanhood (associated with domesticity) and masculinity (associated with tough, competitive work practices):

“In the cities, controlled, regulated, bought and sold -- like women -- men outside the small, privileged, and shrinking upper class abandoned the image of sensitivity, social grace, and emotionality that had been popular in the previous two centuries, abandoned the notion of the “gentleman” who did not soil his hands with work, and adopted an image, still popular today, of hardheartedness, of harshness and brutality, toughness, *realism* (1985: 201).

In their valuable accounts of the role of organizational processes in the construction of gender, social constructionists have been plagued by two key problems. First, accounts are often haunted by the shadow of biology -- the skeleton in the theoretical closet if you will! It is almost linguistically impossible to refer to ‘men’ and ‘women’ without implicitly referencing biological differences. To speak of men or “male” workers adopting new forms of masculinity, as French (1985) does for example, cannot help but suggest that masculinity is a form of cultural dressing on a distinct, and preexisting biological form.

Rakow (1986: 12) has gone further than most in addressing the problem of biology by arguing that “the relationship between biology and culture can no longer be assumed to be a simple layering of one on top of the other, resulting in cultural differences added on to already existing biological differences between two pre-given sexes.” Refuting the notion of two distinct and dimorphic sexes, she goes on to argue that “[T]wo sexes are created out of a variety. Other combinations of chromosome patterns and secondary sex characteristics exist than what is considered male and female” (1986: 20-21). In her argument Rakow draws attention to the powerful labeling process that underlies gender divisions and is discriminatory not only to those labeled ‘women’ but to those who are either unwilling (e.g. “homosexuals”) or unable (e.g. “hermaphrodites”) to conform to the two ideal-typical (i.e. heterosexual) notions of ‘men’ and ‘women.’

Second, social constructionism is often dogged by essentialist accounts which suggest that characteristics associated with femininity e.g., caring, co-operation, are somehow rooted in women’s essential character. Rosener (1990), for example, contends that organizations are marked by a traditional ‘command-and-control’ leadership style associated with ‘men’ which can be contrasted with an ‘interactive’ leadership style -- involving a concern with sharing and cooperation -- that is associated with ‘women’. A curious variation of the essentialist account argues that ‘feminine’ characteristics, although originating with ‘women,’ can be learned by men and that, vice-versa, ‘masculine’ characteristics (i.e. those originating from men) can be adopted by women. This paradoxical relationship suggests that femininity and masculinity are not fixed categories, and that attempts to define them (especially in relational terms) will always be problematic, contingent upon local conditions in society and organization, and in a constant state of flux.

Postmodernism and Gender

In recent years feminist postmodernist accounts have provided new ways of thinking about the problem of discrimination at work. These accounts have largely overcome the

sex/gender dichotomy by problematizing its very existence, focusing on issues of such as subjectivity, discourse, knowledge and power:

“Feminist poststructuralist approaches deny the central humanist assumption that women and men have essential natures. They insist on the social construction of gender in discourse, a social construction which encompasses desire, the unconscious and conscious emotional life” (Weedon, 1993: 167).

From this perspective people are gendered through discourses which not only construct images of typical manhood and womanhood, but typically privilege one over the other through a series of understandings (‘knowledge’) and practices:

“Gendered subject positions are constituted in various ways by images of how one is expected to look and behave, by rules of behavior to which one should conform, reinforced by approval or punishment, through particular definitions of pleasure which are offered as natural and imply ways of being a girl or woman and by the absence within particular discourses of any possibility of negotiating the nature of femininity and masculinity. . . . The use of reason, logic and science...guarantees [the] naturalness of patriarchal social structures” (Weedon, 1993: 99).

Acker (1992), in a piece reminiscent of Rakow’s (1984) argument, refers to gender as:

“patterned, socially produced, distinctions between female and male, feminine and masculine. Gender is not something that people are, in some inherent sense, although we may consciously think of ourselves in this way. Rather, for the individual and the collective, it is a daily accomplishment that occurs in the course of participation in work organizations as well as in many other locations and relations (1992: 250).

Feminist post-modernist accounts have certainly enriched our ways of understanding gender discrimination but it has not escaped a number of criticisms, namely of essentialism and political annihilation. Ferguson (1984), for example, presented a compelling argument for the bureaucratic, capitalist society as a source oppression (of both women and men). Borrowing strongly from Foucault without being entirely convinced of all his tenets, she adopts a postmodern stance in her assumptions of the embeddedness of politics in language, and how domination becomes institutionalized in the trend to ‘organize everything.’ She has, however, been criticized for relying heavily on an essentialist notion of ‘woman’ and the idea of a ‘female

discourse' as an antidote to existing bureaucratic, capitalist (ostensibly 'masculinist') discourse (Billing, 1994). This is perhaps a more general trend for many feminists who, as convinced they may be about the benefits of postmodernism, refuse to accept the argument that essentialism is irrelevant, and that dualisms (e.g. female/male) must be dissolved (Hekman, 1990).

Essentialist critiques of post-modernism are, however, quite rare. It is, ironically, their very success at overcoming the notion of biological determinism that has raised the greatest difficulties for feminist post-modernists. As Calás & Smircich (1997: 244) have noted, postmodernist feminism's "focus on language and discourse has often been criticized as untenable for feminist politics". In other words, in contrast to an approach which stresses "women's voice/women's experience" that is able to rally actors to a course of action, postmodernist or poststructuralist feminism, through its deconstruction of the oppositions upon which terms 'woman' and 'feminine' are defined, limits the possibility of collective action (Calás & Smircich, 1992; Hekman, 1990). Although at some level postmodernist feminism can be complimentary to the ends of the women's voice perspective, feminist politics based on a 'women's voice' perspective will not likely be successful in achieving their aim of 'women's liberation.'

"[W]hile the women's voice perspective still expects to effect a radical change in the world, which will come to value women's experiences, poststructural feminism is skeptical about these goals. The expectation of making a better world, which women's voices espouse, is questioned by poststructuralist feminism as another attempt to reinscribe a dominant sign in a world that is more complex than what women's voices often believe it to be. From a poststructuralist feminist approach, the work is never done; you have to keep on questioning who you can be as you are today" (Calás & Smircich, 1992: 232).

More recently Calás and Smircich's (1997: 242) questioning has led them to conclude that, "it's not only about 'gender' anymore." Echoing the words of Friedan (1995), Calás and Smircich (1997: 242-245) agree that we need "a new paradigm that transcends all identity politics;" that "pursuing the separate interests of women isn't adequate and is even diversionary," that

“‘women’s issues’ are symptoms of problems that affect everyone.” If the recent name/domain change of the Women in Management division of the Academy of Management to reflect ‘broader diversity issues’ is anything to go by, a number of feminist organizational analysts agree with Calás, Smircich, and Friedan on this issue.

Flax (1990) offers a very different way of reconciling postmodernism and feminism in proposing that:

“A feminist deconstruction of the self . . . would point toward locating self and its experiences in concrete social relations, not only in fictive or purely textual conventions. A social self would come to be partially in and through powerful, affective relationships with other persons. These relations with others and our feelings and fantasies about them, along with experiences of embodiedness also mediated by such relations can come to constitute an ‘inner’ self that is neither fictive or ‘natural.’ Such a self is simultaneously embodied, gendered, social, and unique. It is capable of telling stories and of conceiving and experiencing itself in all these ways” (Flax 1990: 232).

This approach offers a valuable framework with which to explore the relationship of the gendered self and organizational discourse.

CONSTRUCTING MASCULINITY

Until recently the sex/gender and organizations debate largely focused on how organizational processes constructed discriminatory images of women. The question of masculinity remained under-theorized, often unspoken or implicit. In the words of Collinson and Hearn, “[M]en and masculinities are frequently central to organizational analysis, yet rarely the focus of interrogation. They remain taken for granted and hidden” (1994: 2). Feminist accounts (particularly social constructionist and poststructuralist accounts) have opened up the space for analyzing the links between ‘men,’ ‘masculinity,’ ‘power/knowledge,’ and gender discrimination. By focusing on masculinity, organizational theorists can begin to unravel not only the processes involved in gender discrimination, not only some of the key actors (‘men’) involved in those processes, but also the processes by which those actors come to acquire and maintain their gendered identities.

Definitions of masculinity, as we have seen above, vary from the crudely biological and essentialist to varying social constructionist and poststructuralist accounts, with varying results. Field's (1998) crudely biological account, for example, is somewhat troubling in its implications for the study of organizational behavior; "for most mammals (and that of course includes humans), the basic body plan is female and stays that way until told otherwise by masculine hormones (1998: 145). Equally troubling is Hofstede's (1980) essentialist use of the terms 'masculinity' and 'femininity' and its reproduction in various accounts (cf. Redpath & Nielsen, 1997). From the social constructionist perspective masculinity is an achieved status. "People learn what behaviors and attitudes they should have according to their label -- male or female. Further, when a male is acting in culturally condoned gender-appropriate ways, he is viewed as *masculine*, and when a female is acting in gender-appropriate ways, she is seen as *feminine* (Richardson, 1981). Although this approach is problematic in suggesting that 'males' acquire 'masculinity,' it is nonetheless valuable in focusing attention on what is considered gender-appropriate behavior in a given organization or society, and how that might impact discriminatory practices.

Kimmel (1987: 14) broadens the focus by suggesting that "masculinity and femininity are socially constructed within a historical context of gender relations." This perspective suggests that what it means to be a 'man' and what characteristics are to count as 'masculine' will vary over time and in different contexts. If this is so, then we might expect to find differences in the form that masculinity takes in a particular organization at a particular time. The question then is, what are the implications of changing forms of masculinity on gender discrimination? Are forms of masculinity always problematic for 'women' in organizations? Are some aspects of 'masculinity' (e.g. 'new wave sensitivity') less discriminatory in their consequences?

Interestingly, many commentators suggest that changing forms of masculinity do not substantially alter relationships of discrimination. This is quite surprising given that the point of studying masculinity is surely to find ways of addressing discrimination. Kimmel (1987) argues that masculinity is defined in *relationship* to femininity, developed in contexts where benefits

accrue to men from a society based upon the institutional power of men over women, supported by inherited definitions of masculinity and femininity. Thus, 'men' are likely to resist any ultimate change in understandings of masculinity that will alter their power basis vis-à-vis 'women.'

Several theorists raise the issue of 'multiple masculinities' as ways of documenting different (rather than greater or lesser) forms of oppression and discrimination. Mishkind et al. (1987) identify five "traditional archetypes" of masculinity -- soldier, frontiersman, expert, breadwinner, and lord, arguing that they are "archaic artifacts, although the images remain" (1987: 46-47). Although they contend that the frontiersman and the lord are no longer viable masculine roles and that the breadwinner and expert are no longer exclusively masculine roles, they conclude that contemporary men may be left "grasping for the soldier archetype (which) conveys the image of the strong, muscle-armored body . . . in an exaggerated attempt to incorporate what possible options remain of the male images they have held since youth." Alone among recent accounts in suggesting that key discriminatory images of masculinity may be dying, Mishkind et al. (1987) nonetheless hold on to the view that some form of dominant masculinity (the soldier) is still sought by men. They do not explain why, nor even where such a drive for a discriminatory form of masculinity develops.

In a similar vein Fuller (1996) argues that there is evidence of different forms of masculinity but contends that, far from being extinct, different masculinities will be evident in any given time and place. However, despite naming several extant forms of masculinity -- Sporting Man, Macho Man, Business Man, Working Class Man, Middle Class Man, Homosexual Man and New Man -- she, like Mishkind et al., centers her analysis on a single "hegemonic masculinity." Fuller (1996: 228-229) argues that underlying *all* conventional constructions of masculinity is a single idealized form based on the deep-rooted notion of unequal power relations between 'men' and 'women:' masculinity acts as an idealized code with its own script, which in patriarchal societies values men over women:

“Cultural scenarios relating to hegemonic masculinity are available as patterns for the individual production of corresponding interpersonal and intrapsychic scripts: individual men are presented with an idealised form of masculinity which they *may* adopt *in full, or part, or reject* (1996: 228-229).

Fuller (1996) and Kimmel (1987) both draw upon Connell’s (1987) notion of ‘hegemonic masculinity’ as part of a gendered interrelation “that is centered on a single structural fact, the global dominance of men over women.” For him

“Hegemonic masculinity’ is always constructed in relation to various subordinated masculinities as well as in relation to women. . . . The most important feature of contemporary hegemonic masculinity is that it is heterosexual, being closely connected to the institution of marriage; and a key form of subordinated masculinity is homosexual” (1987: 183, 186).

This provides valuable insights into the study of how certain forms of masculinity and different forms of femininity become subordinated to a dominant form of masculinity. However there are several problems with the notion of hegemonic masculinity. First, while it may be true that historically masculine and feminine behaviors were defined in relationship to heterosexual marriage, it does not fully explain why such a narrow focus has maintained its force in today’s world. Is it not possible for different forms of masculinity to gain prominence in some times and situations? For example, does talk of feminist organization (Robbins, 1998) mask the existence of new forms of masculinity (and femininity)?

Second, there appear to be different forms, or at least contours, of hegemonic masculinity; Mishkind et al. (1987), for instance, suggest five dominant forms, while Morris (1997) identifies four. What bearing does this have on the study of dominant forms of masculinity? Is hegemonic masculinity reducible to male dominance over women and, if so, how is that maintained in the face of various social and legislative changes?

Third, if indeed hegemonic masculinity is simply about male dominance, what is the point of studying ‘multiple masculinities?’ According to Collinson and Hearn (1994), by uncovering the different ways that men’s power, discourses and practices are developed and maintained we are better placed to resist and address discrimination at work. Fuller (1996), on

the other hand, argues that the study of masculinity is reducible to the study of ways to resist and overcome hegemonic masculinity? One might ask how it is overcome if it retains its hegemonic force?

Fourth, if, as Connell (1987: 184) argues, “the cultural ideal (or ideals) of masculinity need not correspond at all closely to the actual personalities of the majority of men,” then how is it sustained? This seems to fly in the face of current, postmodernist thinking which argues that gendered subjectivities are created and maintained through discursive *practices*. Certainly Gramsci (1978), from whom Connell borrows the notion of hegemony, had in mind an ideological force rooted in cultural practice and leadership. In this regard ‘men’ would have to maintain a position of ‘organic leadership’ to retain hegemony over women! What happens when a large number of women enter a situation of organizational leadership and discourses of appropriate behavior change?

Finally, in the hegemonic masculinity framework there is little scope for the development of dominant images of femininity. “All forms of femininity in this society are constructed in the context of the overall subordination of women to men” (Connell, 1987: 186-7). Does this mean that forms of discourse that favor or value ‘women’ over ‘men’ or rate ‘women’ and ‘men’ equally are impossible? If so, how is it possible to address discriminatory practices?

MASCULINITY IN ORGANIZATIONS

Over twenty years ago Kanter (1977), in her foundational work on women in large, formal organizations, noted that the day-to-day experiences of women differed markedly from their male counterparts, largely as a result of the power men possessed by virtue of their maleness and their formal position in the organization. For Kanter, issues of sex and power were related, but not inseparable; men had power because of their ability to perform certain tasks, effect change and in general ‘get things done.’ The ‘masculine ethos’ she aptly identified may be one of the first attempts to depict organizations as fundamentally gendered, with very definite roles prescribed for women and men. Although Kanter detects nothing subversive or systemic

about the ways in which men are advantaged, she does identify a taken-for-granted masculine culture of management, supported by women both at home and at work as ‘office wives.’ Around the same time, Hofstede’s (1980) research on the worldwide IBM organization examined differences in national cultures that have been oftentimes appropriated by organizational researchers to study cultures within organizations themselves. One of Hofstede’s dimensions is what he calls ‘masculinity,’ a set of values predicated on the predominant socialization pattern for men to be more assertive and for women to be more nurturing. Clearly this notion of masculinity is a very rigid one that is culturally-specific to Western post-industrial societies. ‘Masculinity’ is therefore used in a very traditional way (Mills & Simmons, 1995), viewed as an overflowing of machismo, neglecting the commonsense reality that other kinds of masculinity are expressed in any given culture, and that masculinity takes different forms in different cultures (Woodward, 1996). Despite this limitation, what Hofstede labels ‘masculine’ can be helpful in describing a dimension upon which national and organizational cultures differ, even if there is nothing definitively ‘manly’ about what he labels masculine.

As feminist scholarship continued to explore gendered power relations in organizational contexts, attention slowly began to be paid to men and masculinity. Highlighting the ways in which men and masculinities are central to organizational analysis, yet rarely examined directly, Collinson and Hearn (1994: 13) depict five types of masculinities that “remain pervasive and privileged,” any or all of which can be enacted in the social contexts of formal organizations. Identifying the multiple masculinities of authoritarianism (intolerant of dissent or difference), paternalism (using authority to protect others), entrepreneurialism (hard-nosed and competitive), informalism (informal currency creating in- and out-groups) and careerism (preoccupation with hierarchical advancement) suggests that no one masculinity is hegemonic in *all* situations, even if these masculinities are more prevalent than others. Despite naming these different forms of masculinity, there is little attention directed toward the impact of having one particular form of hegemonic masculinity, or how the tensions between masculinities is resolved in organizational settings. Collinson and Hearn (1994) recognize that these masculinities can cause inherent

conflict in men as they are torn between individualistic competition and solidarity of men as a group, yet leave unexplored the significance of these multiple masculinities, how this contributes to discriminatory practices, and how a multiplicity of forms actually extends gender-based theorizing beyond the long-acknowledged male-dominance in organizational cultures, processes and structures.

The association between masculinity and management ideology and practice has perhaps been made most clear by Collinson and Hearn (1996), who continue to uncover the taken-for-granted assumptions of what constitutes ‘good’ management (and implicitly good ‘men’). Historically management and men have been examined simultaneously because most managers were men. The result was an unquestioned association between men and powerful organizational actors, which infiltrated management thought by silencing gendered aspects of organization. As such, views of what constitutes effective management became “imbued with particular notions of masculinity” (Collinson & Hearn, 1996: 4). Management and masculinities can therefore be usefully considered as relational constructs, culturally and historically produced and reproduced in ways that seem to strengthen the hegemony of masculinity, in whatever particular form that may take.

Increasingly we are seeing that femininity and masculinity are not essentialized constructs, rather ones that can take on a variety of characteristics, shift over time and between contexts (Connell, 1987; Hearn, 1992; Morgan, 1992). This development is a logical extension of the attention now being paid to workforce diversity (e.g. Prasad, Mills, Elmes & Prasad, 1997), with the impact of differences in class, race, sex, age, sexual orientation and religion resulting in fragmented concepts of masculinity and femininity. As such, what constitutes ‘femininity’ and ‘masculinity’ is now being seriously questioned, and along with it the utility of these concepts in guiding organizational research.

Despite the ambiguity surrounding exactly what ‘masculinity’ is, there remains little doubt that in patriarchal societies, what is associated with masculinity typically dominates that associated with femininity. Here Connell’s (1987) concepts of ‘hegemonic masculinity’ and

‘emphasized femininity’ are once again appropriated to attempt to both illustrate the thoughts and actions present in a wide variety of organizational contexts, and critique the status quo based on its systems of relative advantage and disadvantage. The use of these concepts does help us see how some forms of masculinity are subordinated to others (e.g. homosexual/heterosexual, black/white, blue collar/middle class, wimp/jock), yet at the same time does very little to explain how it is that these notions of an ‘ideal masculinity’ persist despite the sheer numbers of men lacking these characteristics, and the suggested dysfunctions associated with their pervasiveness (e.g. Kaufman, 1987; Maier, 1997). As Connell suggests, hegemonic forms of masculinity are not necessarily “what men are . . . but what large numbers of men are motivated to support” (1987: 185). For forms to masculinity to retain their hegemonic properties, men must find their attributes desirable, at least to a certain extent, and use this desire to subordinate other femininities and masculinities.

Somewhat paradoxical is the omnipresent attempt in theorizing on masculinities and management to define what hegemonic ‘masculinity’ is. Kerfoot and Knights (1996) identify control as the defining aspect of contemporary masculine identity, suggesting a concomitant (even natural) compulsiveness to conquer the weak or helpless. As this attribute becomes reflected in management practice, managers become highly instrumental in their control, depersonalizing situations only to gain extrinsic value as control becomes exercised. In this paradigm, everything becomes a contest, with agency directed toward an incessant pursuit of organizational goals in order to maintain a strong ‘masculine’ identity. Morgan (1996) depicts a somewhat less primal image of masculinity, one that simply reflects the dominant ethos present in the wider society. Masculinity can, however, contain tensions between individualistic and collective motives, many of which are reconciled in organizational contexts. As such, certain ‘masculine’ identities may gain their hegemonic properties, and hence allowed to strengthen and reproduce, through the daily practices in which individuals engage, and hence result in different ‘femininities’ and ‘masculinities.’ This observation reinforces the critiques of gender as fixed, essentialized categories that are uniformly produced and reproduced through participation in

formal organizations. Martin (1996) focuses on competition as the basis of masculinity, suggesting that men will assert their 'masculinity' in order not to lose, especially to women. She suggests that when valuable resources are at stake and when job security is threatened, men will exercise their hegemonic masculinity by doing things such as promoting men as a group, seeking paternalist aid from other more senior men, openly criticizing women, and ganging up on woman as a group because of the threat they pose to men as a group. These actions seek to maintain an image of management as a 'masculine practice,' available to women only to the extent it does not disrupt the current state of male privilege that is representative of patriarchal societies, and the formal organizations functioning in them. This view of management presumes, however, both a degree of essentialism in terms of how 'men' treat 'women,' and an unstated assumption that 'women' as a group would not act in ways to defend their privileges given the opportunity. Again we see a conflation of 'men' and 'management' based on particular historical conditions, yet treated as generalizable to society and organization *in general*.

Regardless of what particular type of masculinity is hegemonic, there exists a tension between it and other subordinated masculinities, and femininity (which according to Connell is *always* subordinated to masculinity of *any* type). These tensions are clearly a part of organizational life, the location of the inculcation of many gendered cultural norms (Mills, 1992). Dominant discourses of masculinity in organizational settings, those that venerate authority and control, will frequently contribute to psychological problems in men. Seidler (1989) suggests that a preoccupation with controlling the potentially uncontrollable reduces men's lives to evaluating self-worth on the correctness of the decisions they make. When masculine identity is secured through effective managerial decisions and actions, a constant state of judging and evaluation is created in which men must constantly 'measure up' to an external standard, one which frequently subordinates individual priorities, interests and goals to externally-assessed success, authority and status. Kaufman (1987) also views the pressures of patriarchy on men to be paradoxical, supplying both the basis for pleasure and pain as men become torn between maintaining a masculine image through their work, and functioning

successfully in personal and family relationships. Because masculinity is a social or cultural construction, it is fragile by lacking a biological reality, and existing only within relationships with women and other men. 'Being masculine' is not always easy, and unfortunately many men inflict psychological and physical harm to themselves and others as they strive to exert their power over others as men in a patriarchal society. Maier (1991; 1997) actually takes these observations one step further by suggesting that 'corporate masculinity' can be psychologically dysfunctional not only for men, but also for the organizations in which they work. The pervasiveness of a masculine ethos, characterized by objectivity, competition and adversarial relationships can lead to a spate of undesirable organizational behaviors, many of which have become institutionalized despite their ineffectiveness.

A more recent trend in gendered organizational analysis seems to be a critique of anything 'masculine,' what we refer to as the construction of the notion of the 'bad masculine.' For instance Kerfoot and Knights (1996) talk of 'new wave' management practices that represent a move toward feminization, ostensibly leading to more desirable organizational outcomes. Increasingly it is being questioned how compatible traditional (which have come to be viewed as masculine) forms of organization and management are with current economic and social conditions, which are suggested to place increasing demands on social relationships rather than technical considerations. The increasing importance of the service sector in the development of world economies, and the need for flexibility to respond to hyper-competitive and rapidly-changing environments have been used to problematize the ways in which organizations are currently being managed. Fondas (1997) makes a case for the 'feminization' of many contemporary management texts. Arguing that 'feminine qualities' have been disseminated throughout management literature, textual analysis revealed (stereotypical) feminine dimensions such as surrendering control and sharing responsibility, helping and developing others, and building a connected network of relationships. Ostensibly the increased prevalence of these themes is evidence for widespread 'feminization' of society; (stereotypical) 'feminine qualities' have been recognized as critical for organizational success in today's competitive environment,

but mainstream management theoreticians and researchers are unwilling to name it as such (Fondas, 1997). It is interesting, however, how the three themes used to argue for a 'feminization of management' closely parallel Collinson and Hearn's (1994) masculinities of paternalism and informalism; it appears to be a source of confusion of whether, for example, a concern with relationships is a 'masculine' or 'feminine' trait, more evidence that individuals seek to categorize traits and behaviors in a dichotomous fashion along gendered lines. Men may form these 'relationships' on the golf course or in the pub, and women in more formal, inclusive settings, but the concern with building meaningful relationships with people cannot be categorized as the exclusive domain of either women or men. By naming a set of 'feminine qualities' that is shared by all womankind, Fondas neglects the multiplicity of gendered identities that women and men necessarily possess. The argument for multiple gender identities has now been developed and widely supported (e.g. Brittan, 1989; Carrigan, Connell & Lee, 1985; Collinson & Hearn, 1994, Connell, 1987), yet the cultural and historic associations of gender and current management practices is ignored when we say that there is *a* feminine style that is now being used in management discourses.

A somewhat disturbing implication drawn from this type of thinking is that 'women,' because of their presumed superior social skills, will become more important in the success of modern organizations. Perhaps the current management trends of empowerment, business process re-engineering and total quality management represent 'feminization' of organizational practices. This argument hold true only to the extent to which we essentialize femininity with a interest in, or concern with interpersonal relationships, and hold it up on opposition to an essentialized masculinity that has virtual disregard for these types of relationships. It is unlikely, however, that the argument can be put this simply. Although one could hardly dispute that scientific management largely ignored human considerations, the human relations school considered the psychological well-being of employees as an important determinant of organizational effectiveness. These 'advances' in management thought occurred at a time when women were relegated to more menial, low-paid work (if they were part of the commercial

organization at all). Considering social aspects of work therefore need not occur in the presence of women, or with their 'innate' abilities to be considerate and caring. Suggesting that all that is bad about organization is 'masculine' creates a false dichotomy that seems to ignore the multiplicity of gender identities (e.g. Connell, 1987) and the androgynous nature of the human character (e.g. Singer, 1976).

Prescriptions for imbuing organizations with 'feminine values' (Maier, 1993), encouraging 'feminist management' (Martin, 1996), creating a 'feminist discourse' (Ferguson, 1984), 'inverting the values' of capitalist masculinist organizations (Calás & Smircich, 1997) or 'feminizing' management practice (Fondas, 1997), although not necessarily without merit, are probably over-simplified solutions to rather complex issues of gender, culture and organization. The mere presence of women will not quickly (if at all) alter the gendered foundations of organizational relationships, or dramatically alter the way in which organizations function if there is in fact a hegemonic property to masculinity, as is currently popular to believe. Perhaps one reason for the inability of a de facto *presence* of women to effect fundamental changes in organizations is the threat this would pose to men in terms of their redundancy. If organizations no longer 'need' men, then a fundamental component of masculine identity would be destroyed, leading men to question what it is to be 'masculine.' At a deeper level, there are a great many institutionalized mindsets and practices that would take time to be dislodged, even if women were present in increasing numbers. This phenomena can be observed as the effectiveness of affirmative action programs and anti-discrimination legislation remains marginal. But perhaps more importantly, it is not the collection physiological female agents that are necessary to make organizations more people-oriented and flexible, inarguably attributes most organizations would be desirous of possessing. Conflating things such as an ethic of care, an aptitude for managing social relations, an ability to coordinate in absence of top-down authority or a concern with democracy and cooperation with 'women,' 'femaleness' and 'femininity' does not do justice to the capacity for all humans to change, or recognize the range of differences within women and men as social groups.

FEMININITY AND MASCULINITY IN ORGANIZATIONAL LITERATURE

The gradually increasing acceptance of gender-based organizational research in more traditional academic circles has seen the introduction of terms such as ‘masculinity’ and ‘feminization’ being used to describe abstract values, practices, ideologies and even organizational structures and forms in relatively unproblematic ways. As an example, introductory organizational behavior texts (e.g. Robbins, 1998) talk of a ‘feminine organization,’ one based on ‘female’ values and structural preferences. This approach is consistent with current trends to essentialize female attributes in isolation from historical and cultural contexts, and present them as challenges to the status quo which is ostensibly masculine because of the numbers, status and power of men in formal organizations. From women’s styles of learning (Belenkey, Clinchy, Goldberger & Tarule, 1986), leadership (Rosener, 1990), knowledge practices (Jacques, 1992), moral-cognitive development (Gilligan, 1982), management (Fondas, 1997) and communication (Tannen, 1990), there seems to be a near obsession to categorize human actions as distinctly masculine or feminine. Part of the problem with these types of categorizations is their separation from what men and women actually do in their day-to-day lives, and what is characterized in society or the organization as ‘masculine’ or ‘feminine.’ In order to meaningfully label something as feminine or masculine, there must be some association with what women and men *actually* do, or at least *aspire* to do. It seems that we still base these definitions on rather dated definitions of womanly and manly behaviors, with the former being comprised of traits such as empathy, caring, sensitivity, collectivity, preference for egalitarianism and a concern with relationships (Fondas, 1997; Kerfoot & Knights, 1996; Maier, 1997; Martin, 1996), and the latter the exact opposite. The reality is, however, that there is nothing innately ‘feminine’ about these traits, only a cultural association that occurred at some point in time that has now been taken to be a fixed category that is somehow the exclusive property of women *as a group*. This is, of course, not to say that these traits are no longer associated with women, or that they are any more or less desirable than they have been in the

past. Although stereotypically feminine traits have been ascribed a lesser value in patriarchal societies (Lerner, 1986; Rosaldo, 1974), one cannot ignore either the cultural determinism of the categories of 'feminine' and 'masculine' themselves, or the continued transformation of these categories as social and economic conditions change.

By staying out of the debate over whether 'feminine' traits are practices are better than 'masculine' ones, we attempt to problematize the use of these constructs for both describing and analyzing organizational behaviors and cultures. There are a number of problematic aspects of the ways in which gendered terminology is being appropriated by mainstream management. First, replacing competitive, ruthless ideologies with cooperative, caring ones (what appears to be the essential difference between how 'masculine' and 'feminine' are characterized) is not a panacea. The economic and social conditions that gave rise to competitive business strategies are not so clearly linked to the 'maleness' of managers that suggests women either would have done things differently given the chance, or that they can now. The idea that that 'feminine values' are somehow anti-capitalist and anti-hierarchical (cf. Martin, 1990; Woodul, 1978) seems to lack grounding in the economic reality of Western economies, namely that of efficient capital markets, mobility of capital, and free consumer choice. Given a capitalist environment in which firms operate, it comes as no surprise that many 'successful' firms adopt capitalist ideologies. Will replacing these with more socialistic ones make organizations more 'successful?' Is there anything particularly 'manly' about a capitalistic ideology? The answers to these questions, we suspect, is "not likely." Although a radical theoretical approach might suggest overthrowing existing organizational systems in favor of those that privilege different individuals or groups, 'liberating' women "so that they may take an 'equal' place in staffing other oppressive institutions and share an 'equal' role in perpetuating other kinds of subordination would be a pyrrhic victory indeed" (Ferguson, 1984: 122).

Second, the excessive use of a binary opposition between feminine and masculine does not recognize either the multiplicity of femininities and masculinities, or the possibility for individuals to possess aspects of both (Collinson & Hearn, 1994, 1996; Connell, 1987; Hearn,

1992; Morgan, 1992). The opposition between categories is a central concern of poststructural theorists who seek to reveal the power relationships that are maintained through discursive practices (Weedon, 1993). In dichotomous thinking, opposed terms (such as femininity and masculinity) are viewed as Aristotelian contradictories, where the two categories must exhaust all possibilities. When ‘feminine,’ for example, is viewed as an absence of ‘masculine,’ then we tend to view every possible human trait or behavior as simply one or the other. Through the creation of opposed terms such as these, the distinction(s) between genders becomes both reified and exclusionary. Stating that management theory is androcentric because of its neglect of gender, and concomitant veneration of a male-centered perspective on organizational matters, would not likely receive much dispute. Identifying systems of relative advantage and disadvantage by analyzing networks of power relations (e.g. Foucault, 1980), silences and omissions in texts (e.g. Derrida, 1976) and the specific linguistic and rhetorical techniques employed in conversation (e.g. Van Dijk, 1994) all suggest that a dichotomous form of understanding social reality is prevalent, yet problematic. Because, as discussed above, the organizational status quo has been confounded with ‘maleness,’ the alternative *logically* appears to be something less masculine, that is more ‘feminine.’ Unfortunately the prosaic definitions of masculine and feminine, and the tendency to not permit a middle-ground position to exist between the two, make these types of prescriptions problematic.

Finally, the apparent disconnection between the daily actions of women and men from the ways in which management literature uses the terms ‘feminine’ and ‘masculine’ makes recommendations to ‘increase feminization’ (or however this may be phrased) sit uneasy with many people (both women and men). What was considered ‘appropriate male behavior’ a generation ago may not, however, be as accepted by society today. It is relatively easy to criticize the “founding fathers” of management for basing their techniques on technical aspects of work, largely ignoring the fact that real people performed these tasks (Willmott, 1984). To hold this view of workers (as mindless, identityless automatons) as ‘masculine’ neglects the changes in society, organization and management practice that have occurred in the past

generation. Times have changed economically, demographically and competitively, all of which have helped redefine the role of workers and managers in formal organizations, encouraging things such as self-management, empowerment and employee development (Bridges, 1994; Kanter, 1989; Mintzberg, 1989). Before we make broad sweeping statements involving femininity and masculinity, there needs to be a clearer understanding of how these categories are in fact understood by individuals in organizations and society, in addition to how the hegemonic masculinities suggested to exist are actually constructed and reproduced in the thoughts and actions of women and men.

CONCLUSION

Despite the longtime presence of theorizing and research on gender in organization (it has been close to 25 years since Acker & van Houten identified the neglect of gender), it remains in many ways peripheral to the study of organization. This seems to present gender researcher with a bit of a mixed blessing; there remains a great deal of opportunity for exploring the nexus of influences women and men face by virtue of their membership in formal organizations, yet there also seems to be some resistance or uncomfortableness with making gender as central to organization as something like motivation or leadership. The interpretations for this marginality are many, ranging from an academy unwilling to dislodge white, heterosexual male privilege in the discipline of management and management research, to an inability of researchers to make issues of gender more than a (implicitly radical) women's political endeavor with implications for *all* organizational members.

Not deterred by these challenges, we (as white men possessing a certain amount of privilege) continue to try to make gender a central analytic perspective from which organizational dynamics can be understood. Through the process of our ongoing dialogue, we found a certain uneasiness with how gender (specifically notions of femininity and masculinity) is currently being represented and used in management discourse. We came to recognize that despite our continued support for studying how institutionalized power relationships (many of

which are strongly gendered) affect individuals in organizations, there were some difficulties associated with studying such broad categories as ‘men,’ ‘managers’ and ‘masculinity.’ As Collinson and Hearn (1994) warned us of, there is a certain amount of exclusion that accompanies categorization; emphasizing masculinity runs the risk of forgetting women, and labeling certain types of masculine behavior implies discrete categories of ‘manliness.’ These analytical difficulties pose real challenges for the use of essentialized constructs such as ‘feminine’ and ‘masculine,’ especially as they are currently being used -- as prescriptions for altering the (ostensibly discriminatory, ineffective, inefficient) organizational status quo.

The feminine/masculine dichotomy is itself at the heart of many of the problems we see in how gender is being used in management education. By essentializing these constructs, isolating them from the historical and cultural contexts which gave rise to them in the first place, suggesting that anything ‘feminine’ is always subordinate to anything ‘masculine,’ and focusing on a hegemonic form of masculinity, it is easy to fall into the trap of making recommendations that commit the same sorts of errors -- substituting a ‘bad masculine’ with a ‘good feminine’ in organizational structures, processes and behaviors. The difficulty in definitively defining these constructs, separating biological from cultural influences on ‘feminine and ‘masculine’ behavior, recognizing a middle ground in the feminine/masculine dichotomy, understanding what forms of masculinity and femininity are hegemonic and how this can occur in isolation from the actions of the majority of women and men all portend problems in uncritically using the concepts of ‘feminine’ and ‘masculine’ in ways that are becoming increasingly commonplace. Although most gender research is motivated by an attempt to reveal and/or discourage discriminatory practices in organizations, there is a risk of the current use of the ‘good feminine’ being equally discriminatory, only to the benefit of those traditionally discriminated against. This end-result is quite consistent with a radical feminist agenda, but one that may have limited efficacy in the long run (Calás & Smircich, 1992; Ferguson, 1984; Hekman, 1990). The concepts of ‘feminine’ and ‘masculine,’ despite their contribution to how we understand the impact of organizational arrangements on women and men, themselves need to be problematized so that we do not

attempt to present simple solutions to complex organizational problems. Care must be taken not to make the spurious assumption that some things (for example rationality, competition and aggression) are ‘masculine,’ thereby almost unconsciously assuming that other things (for example caring and trust) are *by definition* ‘feminine,’ a risk associated with the reification of the feminine/masculine binary opposition.

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